

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1989-04-21

To the b ahá'ís of the w orld

1 Ridván 1989

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2 dearly loved f riends,

3 The spiritual current which exerted such galvanic effects at the interna-

4 tional bahá'í convention last rídván has swept through the entire world

5 community, arousing its members in both the east and the west to feats of

6 activity and achievement in teaching never before experienced in any one

7 year. The high level of enrollments alone bears this out, as nearly half a mil-

8 lion new believers have already been reported. The names of such far-flung places as india and liberia, bolivia and bangladesh, Taiwan and peru, the

9 philippines and haiti leap to the fore as we contemplate the accumulating

10 evidences of the entry by troops called for in our message of a year ago. These evidences are hopeful signs of the greater acceleration yet to come and in which all national communities, whatever the current status of their

teaching effort, will ultimately be involved..63.1

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65 1986–1992 • T h e S i x Y e a r P l a n

66 12we look back with feelings of humble gratitude and heightened expecta-

67 tions at the stupendous developments which have taken place in so brief a

68 period. one such development has been the adoption of the architectural

69 design conceived by mr. faríbuz fahbá for the Terraces of the Shrine of

70 the báb, which launches a new stage towards the realization of the m aster's

71 and the guardian's vision for the path along which the kings and rulers will

72 ascend the slopes of mount carmel to pay homage at the resting place of

73 bahá'u'lláh's martyr-h erald. other developments include: the approval by

74 the central authorities in moscow of the application submitted by a number
75 of bahá'ís in 'i shqábád to restore the local Spiritual Assembly of that city;
76 the initiation of steps to open a bahá'í information center in budapest,
77 the first such agency of the faith in the eastern bloc; the establishment of
78 a branch of the bahá'í international community's office of public infor-
mation in hong kong in anticipation of the time when the faith can be
79 proclaimed on the mainland of china.

**Also outstanding among these developments have been the successful
cosponsorship by the bahá'í international community of the "Arts for
Nature" program in london held to benefit the work of the world wide**

80 fund for Nature; the signing of an agreement in geneva establishing formal
81 working relations between the world health organization (who) and the
82 bahá'í international community; the official approval of a bahá'í curricu-
83 lum for public schools in New South wales, Australia; the immense stream
84 of visitors to the Temple in New delhi, swelling to some four million since
85 that edifice's inauguration in december 1986, and including an unusual
**number of high government officials and other prominent persons from
many lands, among them china, the Soviet union and countries of the**
86 eastern bloc. These, added to numerous other highlights of this single year,
87 merge with the overall record of accomplishments thus far in the Six year
88 plan, presenting a dynamic picture of accelerated activity throughout the
89 bahá'í world.

No reference to such marvelous progress could fail to acknowledge the

90 spiritual and social impact effected by the decade-long episode of perse-
91 cution inflicted with such cruel excesses on our iranian fellow-believers.
92 only in the future will the full consequence of their sacrifice be known,
93 but we can clearly recognize its influence on the extraordinary success in proclaiming
the faith and in establishing good relations with governmental
94 authorities and major nongovernmental organizations around the world. 64.2

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65 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

66 12it is therefore with profound thanksgiving and joy that we announce the

67 release of the vast majority of bahá'í prisoners in iran. even as we rejoice

68 we cannot forget that there remain to be realized the full emancipation of

69 the iranian bahá'í community and the assurance of the human rights of its

70 members in all respects.

in the gladness of the moment, we extend a warm welcome to the two

71 National Spiritual Assemblies being formed this rixvân: one in macau in

72 Southeast Asia, the other in g uinea-b issau in w est Africa.

73 Through the shadow of confusion deranging present-day society, there is

74 a far glimmer, yet so faint but discernible, of an approach, slow but definite,

75 towards the culmination of the three collateral processes envisaged by the

76 beloved guardian, namely: the emergence of the lesser peace, the construc-

tion of the buildings on the Arc on mount carmel and the evolution of

77 National and local Spiritual Assemblies. indeed, throughout the Six year

78 plan, during this fourth epoch of the formative Age, and particularly dur-

79 ing the year just ended, this glimmer, still so distant, has drawn closer. for

80 who could have imagined, even at the beginning of this plan, the sudden

81 changes of attitude moving political leaders in some of the most troubled spots on the planet to break away from seemingly intractable positions—changes which in recent months have prompted editorial writers to ask: “is peace breaking out?”? To any observer conscious of the divine Source

82 of such occurrences, this development must certainly be encouraging, al-though the precise circumstances attending the establishment of the lesser

83 peace are not known to us; even its exact timing is concealed in the major

84 plan of g od.

85 The two other processes, however, are directly influenced by the degree to

86 which the followers of bahá'u'lláh fulfill their clearly delineated tasks. There

87 is good reason to take heart. for have not the architectural concepts for the

88 remaining buildings on the Arc been adopted and the detailed specifications which will effect their realization as splendid monumental structures been undertaken? have we not witnessed the increasing strength of National and

89 local Spiritual Assemblies in their ability to conceive and execute plans, in
90 their capacity to deal with governmental authorities and social organiza-
91 tions, to respond to public calls upon their services and to collaborate with others in
projects of social and economic development? Are these Assemblies
92 not reinforced by the alert, loving support of the continental counselors,
93 the Auxiliary board members and their assistants, all of whose burgeoning 64.5
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66 125 energies are being skillfully coordinated by the international Teaching cen-

ter—an institution whose augmented membership has already displayed a

67 verve, a vision and a versatility evocative of warm admiration?

68 Tempting as it may be to dwell upon the positive features of our progress,

69 better that we should be spurred on by them than that we should rest on

70 our achievements. let us continue, therefore, undeflected and confident, to

71 seize the magnificent possibilities which the mix and blend of these ongo-ing
processes and events allow for actualizing the immediate interests of our sacred cause. These
interests, to be sure, are identified in the major

72 objectives of the Six year plan, on the second half of which we are now

73 embarked, fully conscious of the not-too-distant approach of the holy year,

74 1992–1993, and its significant commemorations.

75 in conjunction with the ever-widening thrust of teaching, we must pro-

76 ceed by every possible means with projects of the most critical importance. work is
continuing on the preparation for publication in english of the

kitáb-i-Aqdas, the mother book of the bahá'í revelation. Arrangements

must now be made for a befitting commemoration in the holy land of

77 the centenary of the Ascension of bahá'u'lláh. The plans for the world

78 congress in 1992 in New york must continue to advance on schedule.

79 moreover, further systematic attention needs to be given to the eventual

80 elimination of illiteracy from the bahá'í community, an accomplishment

81 which would, beyond anything else, make the holy word accessible to all

82 the friends and thus reinforce their efforts to live the bahá'í life. Similarly,

83 assisting in endeavors to conserve the environment in ways which blend

with the rhythm of life of our community must assume more importance

84 in bahá'í activities.

85 regarding the projects on mount carmel, the office of the project man-

86 ager has been established, and a technical staff is being assembled. geologi-

87 cal testing at the sites of the designated buildings on the Arc is about to begin—a step preliminary to the ground breaking anticipated by the entire bahá'í world. hence, we seize this opportunity to apprise you of the urgency

88 for the required funds both to initiate construction and to sustain this work

89 once it has begun.

90 All these requirements must and will surely be met through reconsecrated

service on the part of every conscientious member of the community of

91 bahá, and particularly through personal commitment to the teaching work.

92 So fundamentally important is this work to ensuring the foundation for 64.8

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65 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

66 126success in all bahá'í undertakings and to furthering the process of entry by

67 troops that we are moved to add a word of emphasis for your consideration.

68 it is not enough to proclaim the bahá'í message, essential as that is. it is

69 not enough to expand the rolls of bahá'í membership, vital as that is. Souls

must be transformed, communities thereby consolidated, new models of

70 life thus attained. T r a n s f o r m a t i o n is the essential purpose of the cause of

71 bahá'u'lláh, but it lies in the will and effort of the individual to achieve it in

72 obedience to the covenant. Necessary to the progress of this life-fulfilling

73 transformation is knowledge of the will and purpose of god through regu-

74 lar reading and study of the h o l y w o r d.

beloved friends: The momentum generated by this past year's achieve-

75 ments is reflected not only in the opportunities for marked expansion of the cause but also in a broad range of challenges—momentous, insistent

76 and varied—which have combined in ways that place demands beyond any previous
measure upon our spiritual and material resources. we must be

77 prepared to meet them. At this mid-point of the Six year plan, we have

reached a historic moment pregnant with hopes and possibilities—a mo-

78 ment at which significant trends in the world are becoming more closely

79 aligned with principles and objectives of the cause of god. The urgency

80 upon our community to press onward in fulfillment of its world-embracing mission
is therefore tremendous.

our primary response must be to teach—to teach ourselves and to teach

81 others—at all levels of society, by all possible means, and without further delay. The
beloved master, in an exhortation on teaching, said it is “not

82 until the candle is lit that it can shed the brightness of its flame; not until the light
shineth forth that its brilliance can dispel the surrounding gloom.” go forth, then, and be the
“lighters of the unlit candles.”

our abiding love, unabating encouragement, constant, fervent prayers

83 accompany you wherever you may go, whatever you may do in service to our
beloved lord.

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Restoration of Local Spiritual Assembly of ‘I shqábád

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]